

Rise and Spread of Buddhism across Asia

MEMBER 1 - Tahsin Raihan Robbani

Intellectual Foundations & Rise of Buddhism in India

Slide 1: “From Śākyamuni to Sangha: Intellectual Birth of Buddhism in India”

The foundational philosophical, doctrinal, and socio-political underpinnings of Buddhism’s rise in India, including its early teachings and institutional development.

Slide 2 — India Before Buddhism: The Crisis of the Vedic World

- Vedic Society:** Before Buddhism, Vedic society was heavily structured around rituals and the Brahmanical hierarchy. Rituals were complex, and the caste system entrenched social divisions, particularly limiting access to spiritual practices to the upper classes (Pollard, 2017, p. 24).
- Social and Religious Crisis:** There was growing anxiety over the caste system and ritual practices among the masses. The spiritual inequality in the Vedic order left many questioning the need for such rituals and social rigidity (Pollard, 2017, p. 24).
- Rise of Śramaṇa Movements:** The Śramaṇa movements, including Buddhism, offered an alternative to Brahmanical rituals, advocating for personal meditation and ethical conduct over ritual sacrifice (Pollard, 2017). Buddhism’s focus on individual spiritual efforts appealed to those disillusioned by the Vedic system.

Vedic Society Issues vs. Buddhist Solutions

Vedic Issue	Buddhist Solution
Ritual Dominance	Personal mindfulness, meditation, and ethical living over ritual sacrifice.

Caste Rigidity	Emphasized spiritual equality for all individuals.
Brahmin Authority	Advocated for self-liberation through personal effort.

Slide 3 — Doctrinal Core: A Philosophical Breakthrough

The Four Noble Truths:

1. Suffering (Dukkha) is an intrinsic part of existence, and its cessation can be achieved through the Eightfold Path. This doctrine was a revolutionary break from the Vedic focus on external rituals and sacrifices (Pollard, 2017).
2. The Four Noble Truths offer a philosophical framework that sees personal suffering as a universal experience, not something restricted to a certain class or caste. This universal appeal was critical for Buddhism's rapid spread (Pollard, 2017, p. 26).

The Eightfold Path:

1. The Eightfold Path outlines how to live ethically, develop mental discipline, and understand wisdom. It was a practical guide for individuals to achieve liberation through mindfulness, in contrast to the Vedic rituals that focused on external actions (Pollard, 2017).
2. Unlike Vedic religion, which relied heavily on external rituals and sacrifice, the Eightfold Path emphasized internal transformation—ethical behavior, right speech, and meditation.

Dhamma as Universal:

Buddhism's teachings were open to all people, regardless of caste or gender, which contrasted sharply with the exclusive nature of Vedic practices. The Buddha's Dhamma was a universal solution to suffering (Pollard, 2017, p. 29).

Slide 4 — Building a Community: The Early Sangha

Monastic Community: The Sangha was not only a religious community but also a social experiment that offered an alternative to the rigid, caste-based social structure. Through communal living and meditation, the Sangha provided a new model of spiritual community that was inclusive and open to all (Pollard, 2017).

Inclusivity of Women & Lay Supporters:

1. Women were allowed to join the Sangha, a highly radical departure from the Vedic and even some other contemporary religious practices that often excluded them (Pollard, 2017, p. 29).
2. The Sangha also depended on the support of laypeople, especially merchants, who were drawn to Buddhism because of its ethical conduct and rejection of the heavy ritual burden found in Vedic practices (Pollard, 2017).

Appeal to Merchants: Buddhism's emphasis on ethical living resonated with the merchant class, who found the non-ritualistic approach to spirituality appealing (Pollard, 2017, p. 32).

Slide 5 — Emperor Aśoka & Statecraft

Moral Governance: Emperor Aśoka embraced Buddhism as the moral foundation for governance, promoting dhamma-vijaya (victory through virtue) over military conquest. Aśoka's imperial support was pivotal in establishing Buddhism as a state-sponsored religion (Pollard, 2017, p. 34).

Aśoka's Edicts: Aśoka's edicts, inscribed across his empire, communicated his commitment to moral principles—including non-violence, religious tolerance, and ethical behavior as foundations for statecraft (Pollard, 2017).

Spread of Buddhism: Aśoka's missionary efforts helped spread Buddhism to Sri Lanka, Gandhara, and Central Asia, effectively transforming Buddhism into a transnational religion (Pollard, 2017).

Mini-Map: Routes of Aśokan missions (Sri Lanka, Gandhara, Central Asia)

Slide 6 — Q&A Prompt for the Audience

“Is Buddhism’s rise mainly due to its philosophy or political patronage? Defend with one example.”

MEMBER 2 — Samura Huda

Buddhism in Central Asia: Trade, Translation, and Hybrid Identities

Slide 1 — Title Slide

“Caravans of Faith: Buddhism Across the Silk Road & Central Asia”

"Central Asia, situated between India, China, and Persia, played a pivotal role in cross-cultural exchanges. The region’s oasis kingdoms became vibrant cultural melting pots where multiple traditions, including Buddhism, blended" (Kedar & Wiesner-Hanks, 2018, p. 45).

Slide 2 — Why Central Asia Matters

- Oasis kingdoms as cultural laboratories
- Monasteries + trade caravans = perfect symbiosis
- Merchants as carriers of scripture & art
- Significance of the “cosmopolitan corridor”

The spread of Buddhism was inextricably linked to trade routes. Monasteries and trade caravans formed mutually beneficial relationships; merchants were often responsible for carrying Buddhist scriptures, artwork, and artifacts between regions, facilitating the spread of Buddhist ideas (Heston, 1989).

Central Asia served as a key link between South Asia and East Asia. The Silk Road’s vast network of trade routes allowed for the exchange not only of goods but also of ideas, including Buddhism, which traveled from India through Central Asia to China, Korea, and beyond (Zürcher, 2007).

Slide 3 — Gandhara & Kushan Empire

- Greek influence on Buddhist imagery (realistic robe folds, Apollo-like Buddhas)
- King Kaniṣka: patron of Mahāyāna
- Fourth Buddhist Council
- Gandharan art as global visual template

In Gandhara, under the Kushan Empire, Greek artistic influences, particularly in sculpture (realistic folds of robes, Apollo-like Buddhas), profoundly affected Buddhist iconography in the region. This fusion of Greek and Buddhist artistic styles created a unique visual language (Kedar & Wiesner-Hanks, 2018, p. 49).

Under King Kaniṣka, the Kushan Empire promoted Mahāyāna Buddhism, and he is credited with convening the Fourth Buddhist Council, which helped consolidate Buddhist teachings and practices (Zürcher, 2007).

Slide 4 — Translation Kingdoms (Kucha, Turfan, Khotan)

- Monks like **Kumārajīva** revolutionize translation
- Bilingual manuscripts (Sanskrit–Tokharian–Chinese)
- Buddhism becomes multi-lingual → multi-cultural
- Central Asian women as patrons of monasteries (often overlooked!)

Central Asia was home to multilingual cultures. Bilingual manuscripts from Kucha, Turfan, and Khotan exemplify the cultural and linguistic hybridity of the region. These manuscripts were crucial in transmitting Buddhist teachings to China, where Mahāyāna Buddhism would later take root (Heston, 1989).

"The role of merchants as conduits for Buddhist teachings was crucial. As they traveled along the Silk Roads, they brought back Buddhist texts, art, and iconography, contributing to the hybridization of Buddhist traditions across Asia" (Kedar & Wiesner-Hanks, 2018, p. 62).

Slide 5 — Material Culture & Archaeology

Site Examples:

- Bamiyan Buddhas (Afghanistan)
- Kizil Caves (Xinjiang)
- Dunhuang manuscripts found via Central Asian monks
- Portable objects → cross-cultural iconography

Comparative Table:

Region	Iconography	Cultural Influence
Gandhara	Hellenistic realism	Greek + Indian
Kizil	Bright pigments	Iranian
Khotan	Silk motifs	Chinese

"The Kizil Caves contain murals that reflect a blend of Indian, Iranian, and Chinese artistic styles. These caves were an important center for Buddhist monastic life in Central Asia" (Zürcher, 2007).

"At Dunhuang, the famous manuscript cache includes texts copied by Central Asian scribes and donated by Central Asian patrons. These manuscripts, often translated by Central Asian monks, provided key insights into Buddhist philosophy and practice (Heston, 1989).

Slide 6 — Q&A Prompt

“Is Buddhism in Central Asia ‘Indian Buddhism’ or a new hybrid tradition?” Why?

MEMBER 3 (Kamruddin Ashrafi Nafi)

Buddhism in China: Philosophical Transformation & State Interaction

Slide 1 — “Buddhism’s Journey into China: From Silk Road to Statecraft”

- Buddhism entered China via the Silk Road during the Han dynasty (1st–2nd century CE) (Zürcher, 2007).
- Blended with existing belief systems , Confucianism & Daoism.
- Gradually became a major intellectual, social and political force.
- **Focus:** philosophical transformation and relationship with the state.

Slide 2 — Philosophical Transformation

- Early Chinese thinkers translated Buddhist ideas into **familiar Chinese concepts** (Keown, 2013).
- *Śūnyatā* (emptiness) was explained in simple Daoist ideas like “**wu**,” meaning the world has no fixed, permanent essence.
- Emphasis shifted from Indian metaphysics → **moral self-cultivation**, harmony, and ethics.
- New Chinese schools emerged, For instance, **Chan (Zen)** focusing on meditation & simplicity (Wright, 1961).

Slide 3 — Buddhism vs. Confucianism

Aspect	Buddhism	Confucianism
Goal	Liberation from suffering & rebirth	Social harmony & moral order
Focus	Inner mindfulness, enlightenment (Keown, 2013)	Family duty, ritual, hierarchy
Authority	Monastic communities	State & family structure

View of World	Impermanent, ever changing	Stable hierarchy needed for order
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Slide 4 — Buddhism and the Chinese State

- Supported by rulers for legitimizing power & promoting social stability (Wright, 1961).
- Monasteries became centers of **education, charity, and local governance**.
- Tension: monasteries' wealth and independence challenged state authority.
- Policies alternated between **patronage** and **persecution**, depending on rulers.

Slide 5 — Dynastic Shifts in Chinese Buddhism

Period	Event
Han Dynasty	Buddhism arrives from Central Asia (Zürcher, 2007)
Tang Dynasty	Golden age of Buddhist philosophy & art (Asian Art Museum, 2020).
845 CE	Great Persecution of Buddhism under Emperor Wuzong, monasteries closed.
Song Dynasty	Rise of Chan (Zen) as dominant school

Slide 6 — Q&A Prompt

“How did Buddhism change after coming to China?”

MEMBER 4 — Ramisa Maliyat

Buddhist Art & Architecture: Visualizing Identity

Slide 1 — Title

Seeing the Dharma: Buddhist Art & Architecture Across Civilizations

Buddhist art and architecture evolved dramatically as the tradition spread across regions, absorbing new styles, materials, and cultural meanings.

This presentation follows that transformation from India's early stupas to Central Asia's Silk Road fusion and China's imperial reinterpretations

Based on Denise Patry Leidy, "The Art of Buddhism" (Ch. 1–4)

Slide 2 — India: Origins of Buddhist Form

Sources: Chapter 1 — Pillars and Stupas (pp. 9–29) , Chapter 2 — The Buddha Image (pp. 31–56)

Architecture (India)

- **Ashokan pillars** (examples on pp. 9–13)

Made of polished sandstone with animal capitals (lions, bulls) symbolizing royal authority and cosmic guardianship. Their smooth finish and precise carving demonstrate Mauryan craftsmanship, while inscriptions promote ethical governance (Leidy, 2008).

- **Stupas Bharhut & Sanchi** — structure, gateways, railing (pp. 12–21)

Built with stone railings, carved gateways, and bright pigments originally applied to figures. The structure reflects Buddhist cosmology: the dome as the cosmos, harmika as the axis mundi, and the parasol marking spiritual protection. Scenes filled with rhythmic lines and decorative motifs (Leidy, 2008) .

- **Amaravati Stupa** — later architectural development (pp. 25–29)

Known for high-relief white limestone carvings and dynamic figure movement. The stupa's more open, spacious railing design suggests an evolution toward visually rich storytelling and increased regional artistic identity (Leidy, 2008).

Art (India)

- **Aniconic symbols** like wheel, throne, tree (pp. 15–17)

Rendered with clean lines and geometric clarity. The wheel was often painted in bold colors to signify motion and the spread of Dharma; Bodhi tree shown with lush foliage to symbolize enlightenment (Leidy, 2008).

- **Narrative reliefs** (Jataka stories at Bharhut/Sanchi) (pp. 17–23)

Carvings feature detailed textiles, patterned borders, and expressive animals. The stories unfold continuously, creating a visual rhythm that guides the viewer's eye (Leidy, 2008).

- **Early Buddha images** appear (pp. 23–24)

Figures have minimal ornamentation to highlight purity. Simple robes and frontal posture (Leidy, 2008).

- **Gupta-style Buddha** (Chapter 2 introduction to Gupta shift, pp. 31–32)

Characterized by subtle shading, smooth contours, half-closed eyes, and a halo behind the head. The thin robe clings like a translucent veil, symbolizing spiritual clarity and inner illumination (Leidy, 2008).

Slide 3 — Central Asia: Silk Road Fusion Zone

Source: Chapter 3 — Caves and Caravans: India, Afghanistan, Central Asia, China (pp. 57–80)

Architecture (Central Asia)

- **Bamiyan Buddhas** — monumental cliff-carved statues (pp. 59–62)

Carved directly into tan sandstone cliffs; originally painted in vivid colors like deep blue, red, and gold. Niches were lined with wooden armatures and clay modeling to create intricate drapery folds. Their massive scale symbolized the Buddha's universal protection over Silk Road travelers (Leidy, 2008).

- **Kizil Caves** — painted monastic cave complex (pp. 65–70)

Interior walls painted with mineral pigments (lapis blue, ochre, red). The caves' barrel-vaulted ceilings and central pillars show a fusion of Indian prayer-hall layouts with Iranian architectural concepts. Their structured layout created a ritual path for meditation and teaching (Leidy, 2008).

Art (Central Asia)

- **Gandharan art** — Greek-influenced realism (pp. 57–59)

Figures sculpted with sharp contrasts, deep shadows, and Greco-Roman facial types. The drapery features heavy folds inspired by togas. Color traces show that many sculptures were once brightly painted (Leidy, 2008).

- **Kushan royal imagery** — patronage + kingship symbols (pp. 58–59)

Royal symbols include radiant halos, tall crowns, and thick layered garments. These elements conveyed both earthly kingship and divine authority.

- **Kizil murals** — Iranian + Indian + Chinese blend (pp. 65–70)

Use strong outlines, saturated pigments, and repeating geometric patterns. Scenes show ornate textiles and multi-ethnic clothing styles, highlighting cultural diversity in monastic communities (Leidy, 2008).

Slide 4 — China: Localization and Imperial Influence

Source: Chapter 4 — China: A New Dimension, Sixth to Ninth Century (pp. 81–100)

Architecture (China)

- **Dunhuang cave temples** — large cave network with murals (pp. 86–89)

Interiors covered in murals with palettes of red, green, blue, and gold. Architectural painting creates illusionistic beams, ceilings, and architectural frames. The caves served as ritual spaces, meditation halls, and visual records of Buddhist teachings (Leidy, 2008).

- **Yungang caves** — early monumental carving (pp. 82–84)

Early caves feature robust, blocky Buddhas with simple drapery. The stone surfaces retain traces of pigments, indicating that carvings were once richly colored (Leidy, 2008).

- **Longmen caves** — imperial-sponsored sculptures (pp. 89–91)

Sculptures show fine carving, delicate drapery, and elegant proportions. Imperial donors carved inscriptions to display their piety and political legitimacy, merging spiritual devotion with dynastic propaganda (Leidy, 2008).

Art (China)

- **Chinese Buddha style** — softer face, flowing robe (pp. 91–94)

Emphasis on soft, rounded facial features and gentle smiles. Drapery lines resemble calligraphic brushstrokes, reflecting Chinese painting traditions (Leidy, 2008).

- **Bodhisattvas in Chinese court dress** — rich robes, elegant jewelry (pp. 93–96)

Depicted with long scarves, layered silk robes, and crown ornaments. Colors like turquoise, gold, and red express courtly luxury (Leidy, 2008).

- **Murals & calligraphic painting** — integration of text + image (pp. 88–94)

Murals integrate lyrical brushwork, decorative clouds, and repeated motifs. Text is often included, blending scripture with imagery to create immersive visual narratives (Leidy, 2008).

Slide 5 — Comparative Summary Table

Feature	India	Central Asia	China
Architecture	Stupas (Bharhut, Sanchi) — dome, railings, gateways Rock-cut caves (Ajanta early forms)	Bamiyan Buddhas — monumental cliff-carved statues Kizil cave temples — painted monastic caves	Yungang cave-temples — early monumental carving Longmen caves — imperial-sponsored sculptures Dunhuang painted caves — murals + devotional space
Buddha Style	Idealized, calm , early Gupta influence begins	Realistic, Hellenistic features — Gandhara style	Soft, round faces , flowing drapery
Bodhisattvas	Simple ornamentation , early Indian forms in reliefs	Highly ornamented , royal influence from Kushans	Court-style Bodhisattvas — elegant robes, jewelry
Materials & Techniques	Stone, brick, stucco (stupas/pillars) Rock-cut architecture	Cliff carving (Bamiyan) Pigments, plaster in murals (Kizil)	Stone carving (Longmen/Yungang) Murals, pigments, textile effects (Dunhuang)
Cultural Influence	Indigenous symbols + early Buddhist narrative art	Greek + Iranian + Indian fusion along Silk Road	Imperial Chinese aesthetics , calligraphy, court fashion
Political Role	Early dynastic patronage (Ashoka pillars)	Kushan kingship + Silk Road cosmopolitanism	Strong imperial sponsorship shaping art & architecture

(All from Chapters 1–4)

MEMBER 5 — Mauri Barua

Buddhism as Religious, Political & Cultural Identity

Slide 1 — Title Slide

“Buddhism as Identity: Religion, Power & Everyday Life”

Slide 2 — Religious Identity Formation

- Originally Buddha never gave his teachings a proper system, therefore leading to differing opinions and various schools and sects (Eliade, 1982, Vol. 2, p. 91).
- Meditation and Yoga both tied to Buddhism, especially meditation as it focuses on mindfulness as stated by Buddha/Buddhist scholars. Yoga integrated through Brahmanical practices (Eliade, 1982, Vol 2, p.76).
- Rituals (stupas, relics, pilgrimage):

Visiting a stupa ties every other Buddhist who recognizes that sacred geography. Usually pilgrimage entails places where Buddha has visited: his birthplace, his place of enlightenment, his final resting place. Buddhist men are encouraged to become a monk at some point in their lives (Thurman, 1988, p.156).

- Merit economy (dāna, lay support):

The act of giving alms is tied to a social structure: monks depend on laypeople, laypeople gain spiritual merit, and both reinforce Buddhist identity through the concept of Karma (Eliade, 1982, Vol 2, p.77).

- Community categories:

Monks, nuns, laity: these roles define social responsibilities and status within Buddhist society. Identity becomes embedded in your position in the Buddhist community (Heston, 1989, p.148).

- Cosmology (karma, rebirth):

This worldview shapes ethics and behavior. People identify not just by belief in karma but by living according to it. Karma is a moral system of good and bad deeds. Idea of Nirvana, which is equivalent to total extinction or blissful postexistence (Eliade, 1982, Vol 2, p.105).

Slide 3 — Political Identity

Buddhism becomes a tool for rulers to legitimize themselves, unify populations, and project moral authority.

Mini-table (clear):

Region	Political Use of Buddhism	Example
India	Moral authority	Ashoka
Khotan	Royal legitimacy	Donor portraits
China	Unifying ideology	Tang rulers

Slide 4 — Cultural Identity

Buddhism seeps into culture and everyday life so deeply that it shapes entire societies.

- Literary culture:

Jataka tales which entails the past lives of Buddha, moral lessons for most laypeople and means of spreading Buddhist values such as empathy, compassion, patience (Thurman, 1988, pp.150).

- Sutras influence ethics, storytelling traditions, and education as they were transcribed in multiple languages (Thurman, 1988, p. 160).

- Festivals:

Ritual calendars following days Vesak (day of birth, enlightenment and death of Buddha), Uposatha (observance days). Buddhists who are deeply religious fast on these days (Thurman, 1988, p.161).

- Monasteries as cultural hubs

They performed as education centres. Monasteries drive early printing in East Asia (e.g., woodblock printing) to reproduce sutras. This spreads literacy and cultural exchange. They also were and still are community centres that help the poor and run festivals (Thurman, 1988, p.163).

- Food, ethics, daily life:

Vegetarianism is greatly encouraged in Buddhism. However, majority of Buddhists are not vegetarian/vegan. Buddhism is against the slaughtering of an animal for consumption (Ahimsa), however dead animals can be eaten. Boiled rice is symbolic in Buddhism as Gautama accepted a woman's offering of boiled rice to replenish his hunger during his pathway to enlightenment (Eliade, 1982, p.76)

Slide 5 — Transformation & Decline

- India — decline after 12th century.:
- Hinduism absorbed Buddhist identities, both became convoluted and practiced together, as masses were still Hindus. Patronage shifted back to Brahmin traditions (Keown, 2013, p.27).

Nalanda was still one of the remaining institutions for a long time but later destroyed by; royal patronage ends; Buddhism fades as an institutional religion but persists culturally (art, philosophy).

- Central Asia — Islamization:

Silk road was eventually controlled by Muslim merchants therefore causing Buddhist kingdoms convert for more economic trade; monasteries decline; Buddhist culture survives mostly in archaeological remains.

- China — integration into San Jiao:

Buddhism becomes part of the “Three Teachings” blend (Buddhism + Daoism + Confucianism). Buddhism did not fade from China but mutated to fit into the culture. Initially Buddhist leaders received too much power from being popular and also monasteries exempt from tax (Fang, 2018, p.190).

Slide 6 — Final Audience Q&A

“Is Buddhism more a religion, a philosophy, or a cultural system? Support your answer.”

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